

Skill

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Abstract

Skill is not knowledge. It is not syntax. It is not the accumulation of information about how to do something. Skill is acquired through repetition, failure, and adjustment in a body that meets resistance. AI produces skilled-looking outputs. This is not the same as skill. The difference matters.

A skilled surgeon moves differently than a first-year resident. Not because she knows more. Because her hands have learned what her mind cannot fully articulate. The knowledge is in the hands. It lives below language.

Polanyi called this tacit knowledge: we know more than we can tell. The cyclist knows how to balance. She cannot explain it completely. The explanation, however detailed, does not transfer the balance. The balance is acquired by falling.

Skill requires resistance. The material pushes back. The patient's tissue is not like the model. The proof step that looked clean is not clean. The turn that felt right does not work.

Resistance is the teacher. Without it, there is no skill — only performance.

AI does not meet resistance. It meets data. Data is the record of others meeting resistance. The record is not the resistance.

The syntax AI [1] produces well-formed sentences. The connective AI [2] links structures across fields. The adverb AI [3] modifies how the action is taken.

None of these is skill. Skill is what the subject brings after years of meeting the material and being wrong.

The mathematician who has been wrong about the wall for five years knows something about the wall that cannot be found in any paper. The papers record what was found. They do not record the quality of attention that found it.

This is not an argument against AI. It is an argument for precision about what AI does.

AI produces outputs. Skilled practitioners produce outputs and have skill. The outputs can be similar. The skill is not transferable through the outputs.

A student can read every paper Grothendieck wrote. She will not have Grothendieck's skill. She will have his results, his vocabulary, his framework. The skill that built the framework lived in the years of work that the papers do not contain.

Skill is cumulative in a particular way. Each failure updates not just the knowledge but the body's capacity to notice. The skilled reader notices what the unskilled reader does not see. Not because she knows more facts about reading. Because her attention has been trained by encounters that shaped what she is capable of perceiving.

AI can be trained to notice patterns. This is attention in a statistical sense. It is not attention in the sense of a trained capacity that has been earned through failure.

The body of papers is a record of skill in progress. Not finished skill. Skill being built by encounter with walls that do not move.

The walls have not moved. The skill has increased. The difference between week one and week one hundred thirty three is not more information. It is a finer capacity to locate the obstruction.

That capacity is the thing. It cannot be extracted from the papers and given away. It is where the papers came from.

References

- [1] Rincón, D. (2026). Syntax AI. Preprint.
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- [6] Rincón, D. (2026). Week Nine. Preprint.